James Joyce, Religion, and the Artist

A Portrait of the Artist and the Christian tradition

James Joyce is arguably the most important writer of the twentieth century. Particularly noteworthy is the degree to which his work is indebted to the Christian intellectual tradition. He ultimately breaks away from Christianity and adopts a position of philosophical aestheticism, yet his spiritual and intellectual development remains connected with his Roman Catholic upbringing. A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man is perhaps the preeminent Bildungsroman of the century: a coming-of-age novel in which the hero moves from innocent or confused adolescence toward maturity, or at least the beginnings of adulthood.

The novel presents a kind of rebirth and resurrection within one's earthly, spatiotemporal life. This journey of the soul connects with the Western autobiographical tradition, particularly Augustine's Confessions. Joyce's fictional alter ego, Stephen Dedalus, follows a development that mirrors Augustine's, but in an inverted way. Instead of moving from disbelief to belief, he moves from confused belief to intense belief and then to religious skepticism. The novel describes a young man coming of age, giving up what he regards as youthful religious illusions, and adopting a more creative and fertile stance toward the world. Stephen draws on Joyce's life, but the character and the author should not simply be treated as identical.

A Portrait is a remarkable, densely active text. A great deal happens, and it repays very close reading. I would be tempted to say that one cannot read Joyce too carefully. He is among the most meticulous writers; seemingly incidental details often matter. Read slowly and savour the language. In addition to being a great prose stylist, he stands halfway between poetry and prose: one might call him a prose poet. Passages that particularly move us deserve to be read aloud. This is one test of prose poetry, and Joyce's work withstands it. Reading aloud often reveals nuances that would otherwise go unnoticed.

The novel does several things at once. It can be read as a satire on Christianity, especially Catholicism, and also on Irish nationalism and politics. At the same time, it is a philosophical manifesto. Stephen searches for a new stance toward the world, an alternative to Catholicism's great architectonic system. What emerges is a new aestheticism, an artistic heroism that forsakes the Christian ideal of sanctity for an untrammelled domain of artistic freedom.

Language, music, and a Nietzschean reading

Beyond its philosophical and satirical dimensions, the novel is a poetic masterpiece. Irish English has proved particularly fruitful in twentieth-century poetry. I would connect this, in part, with the colonial relationship between Ireland and England over many centuries and the pressures encouraging the adoption of English. In adopting and reshaping it, Irish speakers developed distinctive cadences and music. There is often a rhythmic, almost singsong quality to the language. In my view, that intrinsic rhythm helps explain the extraordinary flourishing of Irish writing in English. Think of Yeats, a great master of language and of its music.

Although Joyce wrote poetry, his greatest achievements are novels, and they possess the same internal music. We do not fully appreciate either A Portrait or Ulysses unless we hear that music. The cadence and poetic elements of his prose are extraordinary and should not be overlooked.

By the end of A Portrait, Stephen adopts a position that invites comparison with Friedrich Nietzsche. Joyce possessed a nearly encyclopedic knowledge of Western literature and drew on a broad intellectual tradition. Here I read Stephen's development in a Nietzschean light, rather than claiming that every resemblance proves direct influence. Nietzsche's idea of the Übermensch, the person who goes beyond previously accepted moral and religious norms, offers an illuminating image for Stephen as an artistic hero.

The novel covers Stephen's development from childhood to young adulthood in a relatively compact space; its exact page count depends on the edition. In a Nietzschean reading, it illustrates the prospect that inherited religious authority will collapse and art will offer a way to renew Western culture. Through Stephen, Joyce presents one possible form of this liberation. The process of achieving it provides the novel's substance and plot.

Five chapters, words, and the senses

The novel has five chapters, organized almost like music. Themes introduced early are elaborated, developed, and woven into a complicated braid by the end. The opening passage is remarkable and can initially seem almost incomprehensible: a sequence of singsong words and baby talk, difficult to interpret logically. It is indeed baby talk. The first chapter begins with very early childhood and continues into Stephen's school years; it is not confined to the ages of three to seven.

Like Augustine, Stephen is fascinated by words from his earliest days. Joyce would become a preeminent word magician of the twentieth century, so this concern with words and names is unsurprising. It recurs throughout the novel. The first words involve a good little boy, a "moocow," and the partly English, partly nonsensical language used with a baby. Stephen's changing character will be reflected in the way he learns to use words.

In the final chapter, Stephen discusses aesthetics with his fellow student Lynch, distinguishing lyric, epic, and dramatic forms. Earlier, he also speaks with a priest, the dean of studies, but these are different conversations. One way of reading the novel's development is to connect its early, naïve poetry with the lyrical mode; the middle phase becomes epic, turning Stephen into the hero of his own story and his life into art. This has affinities with an Italian tradition of making life artistic. Toward the end, the novel becomes more discursive and dramatic. In that sense, it is partly self-explanatory: attentive immersion in the book reveals the principles by which it works.

The opening domestic scene also provides a microcosm of the novel's themes. The child has uncorrupted sensations. Sense perception becomes central to Stephen's development as an artist because it offers access to this world. He will forsake the other world, heaven, hell, and purgatory, for the world of space and time. As this world becomes central, and metaphysics loses its authority for him, perception gains a more important and dignified task: it becomes the avenue to reality.

The small child likes his mother's smell better than his father's. This is entirely understandable. A child cannot yet follow the content of adult conversation, but sees colours, lights, and changes, smells things, and feels textures, such as the unusual sensation of the sheet on his bed. These impressions precede the intellectual and religious frameworks later imposed on him.

In this interpretation, Stephen initially possesses an innocence that his strict Jesuit education will compromise. When he liberates himself from what he experiences as Catholic corruption and limitation, he regains something of that childhood innocence. It is now combined with sophistication. That combination will make the Joycean artist, Stephen in this case, a distinctive individual. The novel therefore has considerable philosophical ambition, referring both to major themes of late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century philosophy and to the older Western philosophical and religious tradition.

Clongowes, isolation, and the Christmas dinner

After the early domestic scene, Stephen appears at Clongowes, a prestigious Jesuit boarding school in Ireland. The Jesuit tradition is a major intellectual strand within Catholicism and is associated with rigorous education. Most of Stephen's experiences there, however, are unhappy. He is still confused and cannot fully explain what he finds so negative about the school and its education. Three experiences leave a lasting impression and later become material for the novel's transformation of life into art, recalling Goethe's conjunction of poetry and truth.

First, a bullying fellow pupil pushes him into a foul ditch. Such experiences make him increasingly alienated. He is not one of the boys. In this account, an artist is necessarily hypersensitive, and Stephen's sensitivity both produces a feeling of alienation and encourages harsh treatment from the others, which intensifies it. After the incident, he becomes ill. In the infirmary, his feverish thoughts and impressions form a remarkable sequence. Describing a child's delirium is extremely difficult, but Joyce evokes it with extraordinary skill. Anxieties about his father, his family, and religion enter a whirlpool of images and ideas. These early passages illuminate what happens later.

A second important experience is Christmas at home. For the first time, Stephen is allowed to sit at the adults' table rather than with the smaller children. He expects pleasure and joy, particularly on such an important holiday. Instead, he witnesses a bitter dispute about religion and politics. The scene belongs to the period of the controversy over Charles Stewart Parnell and his death in 1891, not the later period when Joyce wrote the novel.

Parnell's relationship with a married woman divided Irish political life and brought religion into conflict with nationalist politics. Stephen's father and Mr Casey defend Parnell, while Dante passionately supports the Church and the priests who opposed him. Stephen's mother tries to stop the quarrel; the division is not simply between all the men and all the women. The child understands neither the politics nor the religion. What remains in his mind is the unhappiness and acrimony among the adults. His family no longer seems emotionally safe: he faces conflicts he neither understands nor enjoys and cannot escape.

This family tension and difficulty in making close emotional connections remain themes throughout Stephen's development. He appears again in Ulysses, older, perhaps more jaded and somewhat wiser, but still troubled by emotional connection.

Father Dolan, injustice, and religious beauty

The third formative experience at Clongowes is corporal punishment, then a common feature of education, especially for boys in religious settings. Stephen is intelligent, conscientious, and sensitive, generally an excellent pupil who avoids punishment. Father Dolan nevertheless treats him cruelly. Stephen has accidentally broken his glasses and has been excused from written work. Dolan interprets this as deliberate idleness.

Their exchange can be paraphrased: Dolan accuses him of breaking the glasses on purpose. Stephen tries to explain that it was an accident and that he will resume his work when the glasses are replaced. Dolan refuses to accept the explanation and threatens further punishment. He strikes Stephen's palms with a pandybat. Joyce describes both the outrage at injustice and the physical pain in surprisingly lyrical language. The hand is imagined like a leaf in a flame: the image is beautiful and chilling at once. This juxtaposition of the horrible with the beautiful and musical continues through the novel.

Stephen does not know what to do. For the first time, his fellow pupils treat him as one of their own. Their advice can be summarized: "We know you do your work. We know you did not break your glasses deliberately. Dolan is cruel; you should report him to the rector." Stephen summons his courage, feels briefly part of the group, and decides to complain. The rector gives him apparent satisfaction, and the boys cheer his return. He seems to have obtained justice and challenged unfair treatment.

Later, however, he learns that the incident has become a joke among the priests. This apparent justice is therefore compromised, and his alienation from the priests deepens. Those charged with loving work in education and religion can be cruel and unkind. His family cannot provide the emotional support he needs, and the Church also seems unable to do so. He begins to feel estranged from the major institutions organizing Irish life.

There is an important juxtaposition here. While learning the Litany of the Blessed Virgin Mary, Stephen also begins to understand poetry. The litany calls Mary a "tower of ivory" and a "house of gold." He wonders how a woman can be a tower or a house. His avenue to poetic metaphor is thus religion. Religion and art remain closely, perhaps inextricably, bound together until his eventual break. The pain inflicted by the real Father Dolan and the unkindness of actual religious authorities contrast with the shattering beauty preserved within Catholic tradition. Stephen is attracted by one and repelled by the other. His confusion and tension are unsurprising.

Belvedere, Heron, and alienation

The second chapter centres on alienation and moves into Stephen's later childhood and adolescence. His father's failures in business make him an unacceptable image of the man Stephen might become. This is not only alienation from a father, but also a growing estrangement from humanity and society, with no clear means of reintegration. Initially, Stephen enjoys a relatively happy summer in Blackrock, one of the book's few happy intervals.

Financial difficulties take him out of Clongowes. He later attends Belvedere, another Jesuit school. In the novel's emotional pattern, leaving Clongowes represents a decline in the family's circumstances; it should not be confused with a demonstrated decline in Belvedere's academic standards. This change becomes connected with a fall from grace

and a loss of innocence. Stephen hears his father recount the rector's laughter with Dolan over his complaint. He had believed he had received justice and charity, but now feels betrayed. His reaction can be paraphrased: "These people are not my real friends. I cannot form close connections with priests, my family, or my father."

At Belvedere, Stephen distinguishes himself intellectually. He acts well and writes accomplished English prose, anticipating his future as a writer. He becomes a kind of aesthetic hero, though he has not yet broken with religion. He also encounters a rival, Heron, whose name suggests a beaked, predatory creature. Heron carries a cane, and with two companions attacks Stephen during a dispute over the best English poet. Stephen will not abandon his preference for Byron. Young men do not usually beat each other over aesthetic judgments, but here poetry carries such emotional weight that the dispute becomes violent.

Heron can be compared with Alex in Anthony Burgess's A Clockwork Orange and Stanley Kubrick's film. That comparison does not establish Heron as Alex's direct source. It does reveal a darker possibility: aesthetic enthusiasm does not guarantee benign moral consequences. A person can care passionately about art and still be cruel. Heron enjoys his aesthetic convictions so much that he strikes another person over them. Stephen meanwhile becomes increasingly alienated and uncertain how to resolve his difficulties.

He travels with his father to Cork, where family property must be sold. He recognizes that assets he might have inherited are disappearing and that his father's financial failures are impoverishing him. The journey contains remarkable passages in which Stephen tries to locate himself. In an expanded paraphrase, the sequence runs: "I am in Cork. Cork is a city in Ireland. Ireland is in Europe. Europe is in the world. The world is in the universe." The harder he tries to establish his place, the more intensely he feels his alienation. Location means not only geographical or temporal position, but a cosmic or theological place. He scarcely knows where he belongs.

Sexuality, sin, and the labyrinth of conscience

Near the end of the second chapter, Stephen wins money for academic achievement and essay writing. He hopes, foolishly, that this small sum will free him from Dublin's squalor and his father's economic irresponsibility. It does not last. Later, he visits a prostitute. This is a fundamental change. Throughout the novel he has difficulty identifying with men, while feminine images repeatedly offer access to the divine. Women seem easier to connect with; men disappoint him. Yet women can also, within his religious understanding, become an avenue to damnation. This opposition torments his conscience.

His departure from Clongowes becomes associated with a fall from grace. For someone formed by Irish Catholic and Jesuit education, this is a steep fall. He is saturated with religion and guilt. The third chapter concerns his realization of what he believes to be his terrible sinfulness. Some passages recall Augustine, though Joyce's language is unusually rich and elaborate.

Stephen is cast into a mental labyrinth of his own making: a labyrinth of guilt and sin. He must invent some means of escape. His Jesuit formation has familiarized him with the tradition of Ignatius of Loyola's Spiritual Exercises, involving careful, systematic examination of conscience. After his first sexual encounters, he feels not merely guilty but threatened by God's imminent vengeance. His experiences intensify that fear.

He begins to think about conscience and to wonder how to escape the burden of sin. One sin seems to multiply into many; there is no sin in the singular, only sins in the plural. It is rather like the word “sheep,” which can be both singular and plural. One deadly sin expands into all seven, and why stop at seven? He feels full of sin, a vessel composed of it.

The retreat and the terrors of hell

He then takes part in a retreat, arguably one of the most terrifying in literature: a three-day descent into hell. In this reading, hell exists within the human mind; no journey to another place is required. A biblical phrase speaks of the kingdom of God as within or among people, depending on the translation. Joyce suggests that the devil’s kingdom can likewise be experienced inwardly. This is one implication of the novel.

Father Arnall delivers sermons of extraordinary power. Rather than assigning every topic neatly to a separate day, we should follow their progression through the pains of hell, spiritual torment, and eternity. The sequence invites comparison with Christ’s suffering, death, and resurrection. Stephen undergoes something like spiritual death under the burden of guilt, intensified by the priest’s orchestrated terror and imaginative descriptions. It does not surpass Dante; perhaps nothing could. But it rivals him in ferocity.

The description of hell first overwhelms the senses. The damned are confined in a prison without light, yet with inextinguishable fire. The fire burns forever without consuming them: they remain continually tortured. They are trapped with other inhabitants, as bad as themselves or worse, who shriek and writhe amid disgusting smells. Devils torment them and remind them that they could have avoided their fate. These reproaches are useless now; everyone’s particular sin is exposed. Groans, shrieks, smells, and flames call upon every sense. It is a Walpurgisnacht, a nightmare, the worst imaginable experience.

Stephen is unlike the other boys, whose minds may wander toward sex, money, or games. He sits in church, white-knuckled, gripping the pew. His response might be expressed: “I am far too sensitive to be told this. It frightens me to the marrow.” He is desperate. This recalls Augustine’s anguish before conversion, especially in Book VIII of the Confessions, though Stephen’s state is frozen and isolated. To say these images influence him understates their effect: they terrify him.

The worst element is eternity. It is already terrible to imagine shrieking, burning, darkness, taunts, and the knowledge that one is responsible. But the suffering never ends. Father Arnall asks the boys to imagine an immense mountain of sand and a bird that removes one grain every million years. Even after the unimaginably vast mass has been carried away, eternity will not have diminished. This paraphrases the sermon rather than reproducing its wording.

Stephen’s imaginative capacity is almost overloaded. The experience is not merely spiritual torture but, in this interpretation, spiritual death: a kind of martyrdom. Afterwards he dreams of terrifying creatures and becomes convinced that the threatened punishment is real and awaits him. He rushes to confess to a Capuchin priest who does not know him, rather than to the priests at Belvedere. He wants the burden lifted without having to disclose it to familiar authorities.

Confession, conversion, and the discipline of the senses

After confession, Stephen feels his soul has been cleansed. His resolution can be paraphrased: “I shall never do anything like that again. I will be a model of chaste piety and follow the straight and narrow.” By the end of the third chapter, he returns to communion. If the book ended there, one could regard it as a great Christian novel, describing his return to the fellowship of believers and a Christian coming of age.

One might compare this with Paul’s contrast between childhood and adulthood: putting away childish things. But Joyce has two chapters left, and the novel does not end with Christian conversion. Stephen first tries to die to the external world, not literally, but by becoming exclusively spiritual. He attends Mass daily and prays constantly. He begins to hope that he has escaped the burden of sin, yet remains troubled.

He is uncertain whether his piety is genuine, whether he practises it correctly, and whether his confession was sufficient. He attempts a heroic discipline of the senses. The world and its attractions are dangerous because the senses give access to it: to the city of man rather than the city of God. He has only limited success and cannot be certain that his conversion is complete. Conversion is not something one almost accomplishes; one either undergoes it or does not. Uncertainty here marks the beginning of the end: the camel’s nose is already in the tent.

In the fourth chapter, his piety leads the director at Belvedere to discuss a possible Jesuit vocation. Stephen considers becoming a priest, but the priest’s manner and the prospect of that life do not inspire his admiration. To him, it carries the implications of a trap, a spider’s web, or a labyrinth from which he might never escape. He remains uncertain both about his conversion and about the priesthood. While considering these questions, he walks through Dublin and comes to the strand.

The girl on the strand and the artistic epiphany

There, he experiences an epiphany. In this interpretation, a Joycean epiphany is a religious experience with God left out: conversion or illumination aestheticized and secularized. Stephen sees a beautiful young girl standing at the water’s edge. She seems held in time. Feminine imagery has repeatedly offered him access to the divine; now he is arrested in a moment of aesthetic apprehension.

His previous worries about sexuality, guilt, sinfulness, reconciliation with the Church, and becoming a priest suddenly fall away. He knows he will not become a Catholic priest. In another sense, he may become a secular priest, a priest of art. Such a vocation is individual rather than institutional: it is not an organization but a personality, a way of standing toward the world.

Stephen’s soul cries: “Heavenly God!” Joyce describes this as an outburst of “profane joy.” The connection between art and religion is crucial. Profane joy becomes Stephen’s alternative to sacred joy, which he has found to be a mixed blessing. Sacred joy brings a burden of sin that could disable the artist and interfere with his development as an individual.

University, independence, and the refusal of politics

In the fifth chapter, Stephen has a chance to become something new. He is preparing to forsake the institutional and intellectual constraints that bound him. At university, he develops his own aesthetic philosophy and becomes an independent thinker. He is not an especially dutiful student. We initially see him in a lecture hall, ostensibly listening but actually thinking about other matters, as many students do.

He is becoming alienated not only from the Church and his family but from Irish society as a whole: a stranger in his own country. Leaving Ireland need not make him more foreign than he already feels in Dublin. He decides to turn alienation into an advantage, becoming a spectator and an artificer who transforms observed life into literature. The conversations in the final chapter deserve careful attention.

One fellow student asks him to sign a petition for universal peace. Stephen refuses. In this interpretation, this reveals an antisocial and antidemocratic tendency. His companions ask what harm signing could do. He will not be coerced into joining them, even if a signature appears to cost nothing. He has chosen his own purposes and refuses on principle. This independence can look heroic, but it can also appear unloving and self-enclosed.

In Ulysses, Buck Mulligan says Stephen has “the cursed jesuit strain,” only injected the wrong way. The Jesuit discipline remains, but it is inverted. In this reading, Stephen refuses collective political allegiance because he sees no political solution to the human problem. Nor does he accept a religious solution. Art alone can take up the slack. These are Stephen’s commitments as interpreted here, rather than a simple account of Joyce’s views on every political question.

Martyrdom, resurrection, and the names of Stephen Dedalus

If Stephen’s earlier realization of sinfulness is understood as torture and martyrdom, the aesthetic apprehension on the beach marks the death of that earlier self. What follows is resurrection. Christian themes are borrowed and secularized. The child and his childish religious beliefs die; a new person, the artist, emerges.

This pattern is articulated through names and symbols. Stephen recalls the first Christian martyr in the Acts of the Apostles. Stephen Dedalus is, in this reading, a Christian martyr, but not a martyr for Christianity: a martyr against it. His is not a martyrdom of the flesh but of the spirit, experienced in the descent into the inferno. When reborn, he will not be the good Christian practising the imitatio Christi, the imitation of Christ. He will be Stephen Dedalus and will no longer require that kind of justification.

His first name thus places one foot in Christianity, in Jerusalem. His surname, Dedalus, is not conventionally Irish. It recalls Greek mythology and Ovid’s Metamorphoses. Transformation is central to the novel, and Ovid provides its epigraph. Daedalus is the great artificer who constructs the labyrinth. When confined, he fashions wings for himself and his son Icarus, escaping by moving into a new dimension: rising above the labyrinth rather than trying to find a path through it.

Stephen has likewise found an escape from the labyrinth within his soul: the labyrinth of Christianity, politics, and family obligation. Art liberates him. Near the end of the novel, he invokes the old artificer as a father figure. He has found a new father, or, as one way

of understanding maturity, decided to become his own father and his own artificer. He will turn himself not only into an artist but into a work of art. Art will not be separate from his choices and conduct. This helps explain both his refusal to sign the petition and his break with his mother, who has been good to him.

The cost of freedom and the final diary entries

Cranly questions Stephen about refusing his Easter religious duty, which his mother wants him to fulfil. Why not spend a little time at church to make her happy? The objection can be paraphrased: “Do not be so egocentric and unloving.” Stephen will not comply. In Ulysses, we learn that he also refused to kneel and pray at his dying mother’s request. In this interpretation, that is cold, loveless, and Nietzschean. The prodigy of artistic creativity is also imprisoned within his ego.

The final diary fragments contain caustic comments about Ireland and announce his readiness to leave. Paris is the destination envisaged in this reading, although the novel’s ending itself announces departure rather than narrating the journey. Abroad, he will be no less distant from others than at home, so he believes he has little to lose. He has burned his bridges with the institutions that formed him. He understands himself as self-created, an artist whose entire life is to become art.

He is not simply a literary artist producing external works; he is also a living artist. Yeats asks how we can know the dancer from the dance. Likewise, in this account of Stephen, artist and art cannot be separated. His closing declarations hover between poem and prayer and deserve to be read in light of the journey that precedes them.

One of the final diary entries declares: “I go to encounter for the millionth time the reality of experience and to forge in the smithy of my soul the uncreated conscience of my race.” It is followed by the invocation that actually closes the diary: “Old father, old artificer, stand me now and ever in good stead.” The appeal to the artificer completes the movement from inherited religious authority toward the artist’s own act of creation.